GROSS DOMESTIC BEHAVIOUR

COVER STORY

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IN a nation determinedly coursing towards economic superpowerdom, one uncomfortable truth could well prove to be a dark undertow: our less-than-perfect civic conscience. India may be positioning itself to become the world's third-largest economy, with a projected Gross Domestic Product of $7 trillion, or roughly Rs 581 lakh crore, by 2030, but its social fabric does not show such forward movement. To assess where the country stands, the India Today Group, in collaboration with data analytics firm How India Lives, embarked on a first-of-its-kind survey across 98 districts in 21 states and one Union territory asking 9,188 Indians not about their income or assets, but about decency, empathy and integrity, a measure that we are calling Gross Domestic Behaviour (GDB).

And the findings are far from happy—61 per cent of Indians are willing to pay bribes to get work done; 52 per cent approve of cash transactions to avoid taxes; 69 per cent believe male members should have the final say in household matters; and half of the country's population is opposed to interfaith or inter-caste marriages. Numbers that suggest that India's economic ascendancy has not seen a corresponding elevation in our commitment to what should underpin it: civic behaviour, equity and social responsibility.

It was the contradiction between India's global economic ambitions and its domestic behavioural reality that prompted INDIA TODAY to undertake this pioneering survey. Even as Prime Minister Narendra Modi holds out the promise and vision of a "Viksit Bharat" (Developed India), the path to true development cannot be paved solely with GDP numbers and infrastructure projects. India's journey to developed-nation status requires not just economic transformation but an attendant behavioural revolution—one that nurtures inclusivity, respect for rules, gender equality and civic responsibility.

Far from being some alien values imported from elsewhere, these are ideals that are deeply rooted in the Indian Constitution itself. Article 51A, introduced through the 42nd Amendment, lays out the fundamental duties of every citizen—moral obligations designed to strengthen the nation's social fabric. These duties urge citizens to promote harmony and the spirit of universal fraternity across religious, linguistic and regional divides; safeguard public

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